



THE RITUAL OF SUMO

A sumo match is filled with symbolism, even before the fighting starts. The rituals for the top sumos are allowed to go on for four minutes before the judges make them begin to fight. The ritual fires up the spectators to feverish excitement.



1 The purification

At the start, the sumo rinses his mouth with water, the source of purity, and wipes his body with a paper towel. He then scatters a handful of salt into the ring to purify it.



2 The leg lift

The wrestler repeats certain ritualistic motions, such as raising his arms to the side as well as raising a leg up high and stamping it down hard on the ground.



3 The glare

The contestants then face each other and, crouching forward, place their fists on the floor. They then glare fiercely at each other before hurling themselves together for the fight.



DOHYO-IRI

The formal ceremony held in the ring at the start of the match is called the *Dohyo-iri*. The sumo contestants each wear an apron made of silk, beautifully decorated with rich embroidery and hemmed with gold, which they will remove for the fight. The senior judge, the *gyoji*, wears a traditional kimono. The wrestlers form a circle around the ring, then in turn, each one claps his hands to attract the attention of the gods, before performing movements to drive evil from the ring.

A wrestler may grip onto an opponent's *mawashi* to force him to the ground.

THE FIGHT

A bout of sumo is won by a wrestler forcing his opponent out of the ring or hurling him to the ground within it. No part of the body may touch the ground except the feet. Slapping, pushing, tripping, and judo-style flips are allowed.

